

BOLLYWOOD'S CHINA FORAYS



Haqeeqat (1964)
One of Indian cinema's finest war dramas, this Dharmendra-starrer shows the toll of war on soldiers. Its track 'Ab Tumhare Hawaale Watan Saathiyon' ranks as one of the most memorable anthems to date.

Tubelight (2017)
Kabir Khan's drama strips Salman Khan of his machismo and has him essay a mentally-challenged man who comes to the rescue of a Chinese mother-son duo in danger during the Indo-China conflict.

Paltan (2018)
J.P. Dutta, the godfather of war dramas in Hindi cinema, brought to life the 1967 Nathu La and Cho La clashes along the Sikkim border, one of the less-documented battles between the two nations.





Subedar Joginder Singh (2018)
Gippy Grewal stars in this Punjabi film, a biopic of Joginder Singh who was posthumously awarded the Param Vir Chakra for his valour and sacrifice at the post of Bum La Pass in Tawang valley in the 1962 war.

and promoted to the rank of Lieutenant Colonel as well as being awarded with a Param Vir Chakra, India's highest military recognition.

WARY JINGOISM

Making a film antagonising China is not as straightforward as making one bashing Pakistan. As Lt Gen Sharma points out, there's more at stake. "The India-China relationship is precarious," he says. "It is not a question of movies alone but the larger ambit of a relationship with a country which is powerful and with whom we have trade worth $120 billion." Such is China's financial clout that even Hollywood hasn't had many narratives with Beijing as the bad guy. In *Red Carpet: Hollywood, China, and the Battle for Cultural Supremacy*, author Erich Schwartzel writes how Hollywood studios often make movies aimed at appealing to Chinese citizens, taking care not to offend the Communist Party so that they can leverage China's film industry.

With the highest number of theatrical screens in the world—80,000—Bollywood, too, has benefitted from the immense opportunity to expand business in the second largest economy of the world. Hindi films like *Dangal*, *Secret Superstar*, *Andhadhun*, *Hindi Medium* and *Bajrangi Bhaijaan* have done stellar business in China, with *Dangal* grossing Rs 1,300 crore, four times more than its collections in India. "China is a master of coercion. If Bollywood starts making more such films, they will get annoyed and not buy your films. Bollywood will do a back flip," says Lt Gen Sharma.

That's not deterring the makers of *Battle of Galwan*, which will draw from contested facts. While India lost 20 soldiers and killed four, Australian publication *The Klaxon* reports Chinese casualties to be as high as 41. Lt Gen Sharma says that the filmmakers have to tread cautiously given the "touchy" nature of the incident and how fresh it is in the minds of both nations. "In all these stories, truth becomes the first casualty," he says. "Till date, there are conjectures as to what happened. It's not an easy film to make."

Moreover, while *120 Bahadur* didn't create ripples at the box office, it did earn plaudits for technical accomplishments like cinematography. Unlike most war dramas, it veered from jingoism and excessive criticism of the then-Indian government, which are much-favoured and successful tropes of the genre in the current atmosphere. "I wanted to make it real," says Ghai. "I wanted the battle scenes to feel like the audiences are in the conflict. There's no slow motion and gravity-defying stunts." Chinese actors based in Kuala Lumpur were flown in, as well as Tibetans cast, to fit the parts of generals and soldiers in the foreign army. An average shoot day would see Ghai lead a crew of 600-800 people, working in locations in Ladakh as high as 13,000-14,000 feet. "There was not a single green screen shot," he says. "It was done all on location."

Ghai's film met with the approval of army chief General Upendra Dwivedi, who was visibly moved by the film, as well as his brother, Lieutenant General Rajiv Ghai, who headed Operation Sindoor. What the director wants now is for his ailing father to recover soon and see the tale he narrated brought to life on the silver screen. "My sole motive in telling the story was [to show] that as long as there are men like this guarding the country, we can sleep well," says Ghai. ■